

The Rise of Open Source in India

The future of open source in the country is bright, backed by the Indian government's Digital India initiative and the announcement of its Open Source Policy. Let's take a look at the main reasons that have led to this promising scenario.

India is no longer just a nation of diverse cultures and languages, but has also become a huge market for software and various technology offerings – ranging from operating systems and productivity tools, to desktop servers and cloud solutions. Prime Minister Narendra Modi intensified these tech-focused developments by launching his flagship 'Digital India' campaign in July 2015.

Andrew Aitken, general manager and global open source practice leader, Wipro, believes that open source is rapidly gaining popularity in India through the adoption practices of numerous government agencies, small and large businesses, and individual developers. "Part of this is due to its perceived cost advantages and the fact that Indian GSIs (global systems integrators) are supporting many offshore clients with large open source projects. Many Indian schools and academies are also teaching open source as a regular part of their technical curriculum," Aitken told *Open Source For You*.

One of the major factors behind the success of open source in India is its ease of deployment. "There are as many deployments of open source as there are of proprietary software nowadays," says Adnyesh Dalpati, director – solution architect and presales, Alef Mobitech.

Anant Kumar, head of product engineering and IT, Bharti Airtel, also acknowledges the ease of switching to open source. "It is easier to deploy open source technologies compared to proprietary ones as these are meant for specific use cases," Kumar says, citing the availability of documentation and community support as the other key benefits of opting for open source.

A democratic way of software development

Experts believe that young developers often get attracted towards open source due to its democratic nature. Open source has evolved from the era of GNU and the free software movement that began in the late 90s and early 2000s.

"Young developers are biased towards action," says Monojit Basu, founder and director, TechYugadi IT Solutions and Consulting. "Open source enables them to jump into coding and developing solutions faster. They do not wait for

training – they scan the source code or tap into the always-awake developer community," he adds.

Dalpati of Alef Mobitech says that many domestic

companies in India have started encouraging developers to participate in the community and contribute to the existing code base. "Indian companies are majorly encouraging developers to contribute to the open source community so that more and more users start using the open source applications or frameworks and, in turn, help in improving software development," Dalpati asserts.



Open source developers are in demand

Contribution to open source communities helps young developers even land their dream jobs. Aitken states that Wipro and many of its clients look for open source talent. "We are looking for developers with the skills and mindset to be open source developers. Moreover, the demand for good open source developers will far outstrip supply for at least the next five years," he proclaims.

Wipro claims it is the first global systems integrator (SI) to establish a defined open source practice. This has enabled the company to engage directly with the open source community and build solutions such as Galaxia and BDRE.

Bruno Lowagie, founder of iTXt, who has been an influential speaker at various tech conventions, states, "Indian developers are not only into open source, but they are also very open themselves."

Ramakrishna Rama, director of software engineering, Dell, notes that open source is helping young Indians translate their innovative ideas and technologies into reality. "Since India is a young country and has a large base of technically skilled professionals, open source creates a great opportunity and enhances their full potential for translating ideas and technologies into reality," he says.

Leapfrogging to bigger applications

IT research analysts forecast that open source will leapfrog into areas such as transportation, smart cities and agriculture in the near future.